SECTION A SUMMARY WRITING (15%)

Read the following passage carefully and write a summary of not more than 150 words.

The rapid development of social media has transformed the way people communicate, obtain information and entertain themselves. Platforms that were originally designed to connect individuals have become deeply integrated into everyday life. While social media can provide valuable opportunities for communication and learning, excessive dependence on these platforms may develop into a form of behavioural addiction.

Several factors may contribute to excessive social media use. One important factor is the desire for social approval. Social media platforms allow users to receive immediate responses through likes, comments and shares. For some individuals, these reactions become a measure of their popularity or self-worth. They may repeatedly check their accounts because they are concerned about how others respond to their posts. The temporary satisfaction obtained from receiving positive feedback can encourage them to return to the platforms frequently.

Another contributing factor is the fear of missing out. Young people may worry that they are being excluded from conversations, events or experiences shared online. Consequently, they may feel compelled to remain connected so that they do not miss important updates. Even when there is no urgent reason to check their devices, the possibility of discovering something new can encourage repeated checking. The constant flow of new content makes it particularly difficult for users to disengage.

The design of social media platforms can further encourage excessive use. Many platforms rely on personalised recommendations, endless scrolling and frequent notifications to maintain users' attention. Unlike traditional forms of media, which usually have a clear ending, an endless stream of content provides no obvious point at which users should stop.

Personal circumstances may play a role as well. Individuals who experience loneliness, academic pressure or difficulties in their relationships may turn to social media as a means of distraction or emotional relief. Online interactions can temporarily reduce feelings of isolation and provide a sense of belonging. However, relying heavily on digital interaction to cope with unpleasant emotions may gradually reduce a person's willingness to deal with problems directly or seek support in the real world.

Poor self-regulation is another significant factor. Some users may recognise that they are spending too much time online but struggle to establish boundaries. The absence of a fixed routine, combined with easy access to smartphones, can make it difficult to control usage. When social media becomes incorporated into ordinary activities, checking a device may become an automatic response rather than a conscious decision.

Excessive social media use can have serious consequences. One of the most immediate effects is reduced concentration. Constant notifications and the habit of switching rapidly between tasks can make it difficult for users to maintain attention for extended periods. Students may find themselves checking their phones while studying, resulting in fragmented attention and reduced learning efficiency.

Sleep may also be affected. Individuals who remain online late at night may postpone bedtime because they continue watching videos, reading posts or communicating with others.

The resulting reduction in sleeping time can lead to tiredness during the following day. In addition, the habit of checking devices before sleeping may make it harder for some individuals to establish a consistent bedtime routine. Persistent sleep disruption can subsequently affect academic performance, mood and daily functioning.

Another consequence is the deterioration of face-to-face relationships. Although social media enables people to remain connected across distances, excessive online interaction may reduce the time available for meaningful communication in person. Furthermore, online communication lacks many of the facial expressions, tone and gestures that help people interpret emotions accurately. Misunderstandings may therefore arise more easily, while individuals may gradually become less comfortable with direct social interaction.

Excessive dependence on social media can also affect emotional well-being. Constant exposure to carefully selected images of other people's achievements, appearances and lifestyles may encourage unfavourable comparisons. Users may mistakenly assume that others are happier or more successful than they are, even though online content often presents only a limited version of reality.

Finally, social media addiction may weaken productivity and self-discipline. What begins as a short break can easily develop into prolonged browsing, reducing the amount of time available for studying, exercising, completing responsibilities or pursuing meaningful interests. When this behaviour becomes habitual, individuals may increasingly rely on immediate digital entertainment instead of activities that require patience and sustained effort.

Social media itself is not necessarily harmful, and its benefits should not be overlooked. The problem arises when individuals lose the ability to regulate their usage and allow online activities to interfere with other areas of life. Developing healthy digital habits, establishing clear boundaries and maintaining meaningful offline relationships can help individuals enjoy the advantages of social media without becoming excessively dependent on it.

Your summary should include:

- the **causes of social media addiction**; and
- the **effects of social media addiction.**

Write your summary in continuous writing. At the end of your answer, state, in brackets, the number of words you have used.

SECTION B WRITING (35%)

*Write a composition of not less than 350 words on **ONE (1)** of the following topics.*

1. Examinations remain a major form of assessment in many educational systems, although some argue that they do not fully reflect students' abilities. To what extent should examinations remain the main method of assessing students' abilities?

2. Community service provides young people with opportunities to develop social responsibility and contribute to society. In your opinion, should young people be encouraged to participate more actively in community service?

3. Food waste is a growing global problem, with large amounts of edible food being discarded every day. It not only wastes valuable resources, but also creates serious social and environmental consequences. What are the causes and effects of food wasting?

4. Young people can play an important role in promoting environmentally responsible lifestyles and protecting the environment. How can society encourage young people to adopt more environmentally responsible lifestyles?

5. Both practical skills and academic qualifications can influence young people's preparation for future employment. Compare and contrast the roles of practical skills and academic qualifications in preparing young people for employment.

----------Good Luck! ----------

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